THE PINECREST

EPISODE 1: Room 214

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, LOBBY - NIGHT

Snow against the windows. A grandfather clock strikes eleven. ISHA (28) drags a suitcase across the marble floor. The front desk is empty.

ISHA
Hello? Anyone?

KABIR (31), the hotel manager, steps out of the back office. He freezes when he sees her.

KABIR
Isha.

ISHA
Ten years, Kabir. You could at least say welcome home.

KABIR
Welcome home. I'm sorry it took a funeral.

ISHA
Where did he die?

KABIR
Room 214. The doctor said it was his heart.

ISHA
Dad climbed Jakhu hill every morning. His heart was fine.

Kabir looks away. Behind him, the clock ticks.

KABIR
Get some sleep. The will is read tomorrow.

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, DINING HALL - DAY

A long table, cold tea. MAYA (52), Isha's stepmother, in white silk. NIKHIL (25), Isha's half-brother, bouncing his knee. Kabir stands by the door with a sealed envelope.

KABIR
Mr. Sood made me executor. I'll keep it short.

He opens the envelope and reads.

KABIR
"The Pinecrest Hotel, with its land and buildings, goes to my daughter Isha."

NIKHIL
All of it? I'm his son too!

MAYA
Nikhil. Sit down.

NIKHIL
She left! She didn't even call him on his birthday!

ISHA
I didn't ask for this.

MAYA
Then don't keep it. A Chandigarh developer offered sixty crore. Sign it to me, and we split it three ways.

ISHA
Dad turned down every developer for thirty years.

MAYA
Your father isn't here, Isha. We are.

Maya leaves. Nikhil follows and slams the door.

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, ROOM 214 - NIGHT

Dad's reading glasses are still on the desk. His shawl is folded on the bed. Isha sits in his chair and finally lets herself cry.

She runs her fingers along his bookshelf. One book is too light. She opens it. It is hollow.

Inside is a folded page in her father's handwriting.

ON SCREEN: Note in Dad's handwriting: "Isha, if I die suddenly, it was not my heart. Trust no one at the Pinecrest. Not even K."

ISHA
(whispering) K...

A knock at the door. Three soft taps.

KABIR
Isha? Are you awake? I need to tell you something.

Isha looks from the door to the note. Not even K.

EPISODE 2: The Offer

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, LOBBY - MORNING

Isha comes down with dark circles under her eyes. Kabir waits at the desk.

KABIR
You didn't open the door last night.

ISHA
I was asleep. What did you want to tell me?

KABIR
(hesitating) Only that the staff is with you. Whatever you decide.

ISHA
That's it?

KABIR
That's it.

She doesn't believe him. The front doors open. Cold air. INSPECTOR RAWAT (45), polished boots, warm smile, takes off his cap.

RAWAT
Miss Sood. My condolences. Your father was a friend to the whole district.

ISHA
Inspector. I want a post-mortem.

RAWAT
(gently) The cremation was done the same evening, beta. There is nothing left to examine.

ISHA

The same evening? Who signed for that?

RAWAT
Your stepmother. She wanted to avoid a scandal before the tourist season.

ISHA
He died of a heart attack. Where is the scandal in that?

Rawat smiles and puts his cap back on.

RAWAT
Grief makes us see ghosts. I'll close the file today. Call me if you need anything.

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, MAYA'S SUITE - DAY

Maya applies lipstick at a mirror. Isha storms in.

ISHA
You cremated him before anyone could look at him.

MAYA
I said goodbye to my husband the way our family always has.

ISHA
In six hours?

MAYA
Rawat said a post-mortem would bring reporters. Reporters would kill the sale.

ISHA
So it's about the sale.

MAYA
It's about survival. Your father left debts you know nothing about. The offer expires on Friday.

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, BAR - NIGHT

Nikhil slumps over the counter, refreshing a betting app. Isha sits beside him.

NIKHIL
Come to gloat?

ISHA
Where were you the night Dad died?

NIKHIL
In my room. Why?

ISHA
Who do you owe money to?

Nikhil turns his phone face down.

NIKHIL
Nobody you need to know.

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, SECURITY ROOM - NIGHT

Isha scrolls through the CCTV archive. Every camera, every night. Except one.

ON SCREEN: Corridor 2 camera, 14 November: "Footage deleted 03:12. User: KABIR."

Isha stares at the screen. Behind her, the door creaks open.

EPISODE 3: The Footage

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, SECURITY ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Kabir stands in the doorway.

KABIR
I can explain.

ISHA
You deleted the corridor footage from the night my father died. Explain that.

KABIR
It showed Nikhil. Outside Room 214. At two in the morning.

ISHA
Nikhil?

KABIR
Your father loved that boy. If the police saw it, they'd pin it on him. So I deleted it.

ISHA
You had no right.

KABIR
Your father asked me to protect this family. I did what I thought he'd want.

ISHA
Dad left a note, Kabir. It says not to trust K.

Kabir's face goes pale.

KABIR
And you think K is me.

ISHA
Give me one reason it isn't.

KABIR
I can't. I can only tell you I loved him too.

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, NIKHIL'S ROOM - NIGHT

Nikhil throws clothes into a bag. Isha blocks the door.

ISHA
You were outside his room at two in the morning.

NIKHIL
(cracking) I went to beg him for money. I owe fifteen lakh to some men in Chandigarh.

ISHA
Did you go in?

NIKHIL
No! I heard him talking to someone. A man. Calm voice. Deep. They were arguing about papers.

ISHA
Who was it?

NIKHIL
I don't know. I got scared and left. In the morning... he was gone.

ISHA
Does your mother know about the money?

NIKHIL
She knows I owe something. She doesn't know how much.

He sits on the bed and sobs. After a moment, Isha sits beside him.

ISHA
Don't run. Running makes you look guilty.

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, BACK OFFICE - NIGHT

Past midnight. A thin light under the office door. Isha pushes it open.

ZOYA (24), the new receptionist, is photographing pages of the old land ledger with her phone. She spins around.

ISHA
Zoya? What are you doing with my father's ledger?

ZOYA
Please close the door.

ISHA
I'm calling the police.

ZOYA
Don't. Not the police. Please.

Isha hesitates, her thumb over the call button.

ZOYA
I'm not a receptionist, Isha. And I'm the reason your father is dead.

EPISODE 4: The Source

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, BACK OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

ZOYA
I'm a reporter. I write for a news site in Delhi. Your father was my source.

ISHA
Source for what?

ZOYA
The forest land around this hotel. Someone has been forging old land records and selling protected forest to builders.

ISHA
And Dad found out.

ZOYA
He found the original registers. They prove the forgery. He agreed to give them to me on the fifteenth of November.

ISHA
He died on the fourteenth.

ZOYA
(quietly) I pushed him to talk. If I hadn't, he'd still be alive.

Isha sinks into a chair.

ISHA
Where are the registers now?

ZOYA

That's what I've been looking for. These pages are copies. The originals are hidden somewhere in this hotel.

ISHA
Why should I trust you?

Zoya shows her a chat on her phone.

ON SCREEN: Message from Vijay Sood, 13 November: "Zoya, come on the 15th. I'll bring everything. Tell no one, not even the police."

ISHA
Not even the police...

ZOYA
He was scared of someone in uniform. He never said who.

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, KITCHEN - NIGHT

Kabir grates ginger into a pan of boiling tea. Isha watches him from the doorway.

KABIR
Your father's recipe. Ginger, two cardamoms, no sugar. He drank it every night at eleven.

ISHA
Who else knew that?

KABIR
Everyone who ever sat with him. Half of Shimla.

He pours her a cup. She doesn't drink it.

KABIR
You still don't trust me.

ISHA
I don't trust anyone in this hotel.
Dad told me not to.

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, LOBBY - DAY

Morning. Guests check out. Inspector Rawat walks in with two constables. His smile is gone.

RAWAT
Miss Sood. You wanted a
post-mortem. You were right.

ISHA
What?

RAWAT
The hospital kept a blood sample
from your father. The lab report
came this morning. Poison.

Maya, coming down the stairs, grips the railing.

MAYA
Poison? In this house?

RAWAT
We searched the staff lockers an
hour ago.

He holds up a small brown bottle in an evidence bag.

RAWAT
This was in your manager's locker.
Kabir's.

Kabir steps out of the office. The constables take his arms.

KABIR
Isha, I didn't. You know I didn't.

Isha looks at him. The note burns in her pocket. Not even K.

RAWAT
Kabir, you are under arrest for the murder of Vijay Sood.

EPISODE 5: The Clock

INT. SHIMLA POLICE STATION, LOCKUP - DAY

Kabir sits on a steel bench, his lip split. Isha stands outside the bars.

ISHA
Did they hit you?

KABIR
It doesn't matter. Listen to me. I didn't just delete the footage.

ISHA
What do you mean?

KABIR
I copied it first. To a pen drive. In case Nikhil ever needed proof he didn't go inside.

ISHA
Did you watch it?

KABIR
Only the minute with Nikhil. Then I panicked and deleted the rest.

ISHA
Where is the pen drive?

KABIR
Inside the grandfather clock in the lobby. Behind the pendulum.

ISHA
Why didn't you tell me before?

KABIR
Because you looked at me like I killed him.

A constable rattles his keys at the end of the corridor.

KABIR
(low) And Isha... don't tell Rawat about the pen drive.

ISHA
Why not?

KABIR
Because I never kept anything in my locker. Somebody put that bottle there.

INT. SHIMLA POLICE STATION, CORRIDOR - DAY

Isha walks out. Rawat leans against the wall, sipping tea from a steel glass.

RAWAT
Visiting a murderer, Miss Sood?

ISHA
Visiting a friend.

RAWAT
Your father said the same thing about people. It never ended well for him.

ISHA
What did he say about you?

RAWAT
(smiling) That I was the only man in Shimla he trusted.

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, LOBBY - NIGHT

The lobby is empty. Isha opens the glass door of the grandfather clock and reaches behind the pendulum.

Dust. Cobwebs. Nothing else. The pen drive is gone.

ISHA
(to herself) Who else knew?

Zoya comes in with two cups of tea.

ZOYA
Found it?

ISHA
Someone got here first.

ZOYA
Then someone is listening to everything we say.

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, UPSTAIRS CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Isha walks back to her room. Maya's door is open a crack. Maya is on the phone, low and tense.

MAYA
(on phone) I told you. She'll sign by Friday.
(beat)
(on phone) And if she doesn't, she ends up like him. I know. I know!

Isha presses herself against the wall, her hand over her mouth.

EPISODE 6: Friday

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, MAYA'S SUITE - NIGHT

Isha walks in without knocking. Maya drops her phone.

ISHA

She ends up like him. That's me, isn't it?

MAYA

You were listening at my door?

ISHA

Who were you talking to?

MAYA

The men Nikhil owes money to. They called me, not you.

ISHA

And "ends up like him"?

MAYA

Those were their words, Isha! Not mine. They want the hotel sold so I can pay them. Or they hurt my son.

ISHA

Why didn't you go to the police?

MAYA

I did. I went to Rawat the day your father died.

ISHA

And?

MAYA
He said a post-mortem would scare the buyer. Cremate quickly, he said, and the debts go away.

Isha goes very still.

ISHA
Rawat told you to cremate him?

MAYA
He was only trying to help.

ISHA
Or he was making sure nobody tested Dad's blood.

Maya sits down slowly on the bed.

MAYA
Then why would he test it now?

ISHA
To put it on Kabir.

For the first time, Maya looks frightened of something other than money.

MAYA
Where is Nikhil?

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, NIKHIL'S ROOM - NIGHT

The room is empty. The window is open. Snow blows in. Nikhil's phone lies on the floor, its screen cracked.

MAYA
Nikhil? Nikhil!

ISHA

He was here an hour ago. I heard his music.

Isha picks up the phone. It buzzes in her hand.

ON SCREEN: Message from unknown number: "Your brother is with us. Sign the sale papers by Friday noon. No police."

A photo loads below it. Nikhil, tied to a chair, a bruise on his cheek.

Maya screams.

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, LOBBY - NIGHT

Zoya is at the front desk. Isha and Maya rush down the stairs.

ZOYA
What happened?

ISHA
They took Nikhil.

ZOYA
Who?

Isha's phone buzzes again.

ON SCREEN: Unknown number: "Tell the reporter girl to stay out of it. We know who she is."

EPISODE 7: The Badge

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, DINING HALL - DAY

Isha signs a stack of sale papers. Maya watches, hollow-eyed. Zoya paces.

ZOYA
If you sign, the forest is gone. Everything your father died for.

ISHA
My brother is tied to a chair, Zoya.

ZOYA
Your father would want you to fight.

ISHA
My father is dead. Nikhil isn't. Not yet.

She signs the last page.

MAYA
(quietly) Thank you.

Isha's phone buzzes.

ON SCREEN: Unknown number: "Old toll naka on the Kufri road. Noon. Bring the papers."

ZOYA
At least take the police.

ISHA
They said no police.

The doors open. Inspector Rawat walks in, cap under his arm.

RAWAT
Miss Sood. I heard about your brother. Mrs. Sood called me.

Isha looks at Maya. Maya nods.

RAWAT
I'll come with you. Plain clothes. Nobody will know.

ISHA
(hesitating) Thank you, Inspector.

INT. ISHA'S CAR, KUFRI ROAD - DAY

Rawat drives. Pine trees blur past. Isha holds the papers on her lap.

RAWAT
Your father and I were in school together. He was the clever one. I was the one who got caught.

ISHA
And now you catch people.

RAWAT
Somebody has to. Don't worry, beta. In an hour, your brother will be home.

ISHA
How can you be so sure?

RAWAT
Because these men want money, not blood. I know the type.

EXT. OLD TOLL NAKA, KUFRI ROAD - DAY

Fog. An abandoned toll booth. A black SUV waits. Isha walks forward with the papers. Rawat stays by her car.

The SUV's back door opens. Nikhil stumbles out and runs to her. She holds him tight.

NIKHIL
Didi... I'm sorry. I'm so sorry.

ISHA

You're safe. That's all that matters.

A gloved hand takes the papers through the SUV window. The SUV drives off into the fog.

Rawat walks up and puts a hand on Nikhil's shoulder.

RAWAT
It's over now. Go home and rest.

His wallet slips from his jacket and falls open on the road. Isha sees his police ID card.

ON SCREEN: Police ID card: "Inspector Karan Rawat, Shimla Police."

Isha stops breathing.

ISHA
(whispering) Karan. K.

Rawat picks up the wallet and smiles at her.

RAWAT
Something wrong, Miss Sood?

ISHA
Nothing. Just cold.

EPISODE 8: The Voice

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, ISHA'S ROOM - NIGHT

Isha, Zoya, Maya and Nikhil sit on the floor around Dad's note.

ISHA
Not even K. Not Kabir. Karan. Karan Rawat.

MAYA
Rawat has eaten at our table for twenty years.

ZOYA
Who better to steal forest records than the man who guards them?

NIKHIL
(slowly) At the toll naka. When he said "it's over now"...

ISHA
What?

NIKHIL
The voice in Dad's room that night. Calm. Deep. It was the same voice.

Silence.

NIKHIL
There's something else. The pen drive in the clock. I took it.

ISHA
You?

NIKHIL
I saw Kabir hide something in the clock the morning Dad died.

He swallows hard.

NIKHIL
I thought it would show me outside the room. I was scared, Didi. I haven't even watched it.

He pulls it out of his sock and puts it in her palm.

ZOYA
If Rawat is on that footage, it's over for him.

MAYA
Then he will come for it.

ISHA
Then we let him think we don't have it. Nobody says a word outside this room.

Maya takes Isha's hand. It's the first time she has ever done it.

MAYA
I was wrong about you.

ISHA
I was wrong about you too.

ZOYA
I'll call my editor. If anything happens to us, the story still runs.

ISHA
Then call her now.

Zoya steps onto the balcony, phone to her ear. Snow settles on her hair.

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, LOBBY - NIGHT

Isha carries a laptop downstairs to play the pen drive. Halfway down, she smells smoke.

ZOYA

Fire! The archive room!

Thick black smoke pours from under the archive room door. The fire alarm shrieks.

NIKHIL
The old registers might be in there!

ISHA
That's what he wants. He's burning the proof.

A figure runs in from the front door, coat pulled over his head. It is Kabir.

ISHA
Kabir? They let you out?

KABIR
Bail, this evening. Rawat signed it himself.

He kicks the archive door open and disappears into the fire.

EPISODE 9: Smoke

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, ARCHIVE ROOM - NIGHT

Flames climb the wooden shelves. Kabir pulls a steel trunk from under a desk, coughing.

ISHA
Kabir! Get out!

KABIR
Not without this!

He drags the trunk out as a burning shelf collapses behind him.

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, LOBBY - NIGHT

Staff throw buckets of water and snow. Fire engine sirens outside. Kabir sits on the floor, his palms red and blistered. Zoya opens the trunk.

Inside are thick, singed land registers, wrapped in plastic.

ZOYA
These are the originals. Look. The forest survey numbers. Your father's notes in the margin.

ISHA
(to Kabir) You could have died.

KABIR
He gave me a home when I had nowhere to go. I owed him one fire.

Isha presses a cold towel into his hands. She holds them a moment too long. Neither of them pulls away.

Inspector Rawat walks in from the cold with the firemen, every inch the concerned officer.

RAWAT
Is everyone safe? An electrical short, they're saying. These old buildings.

ZOYA
(under her breath) Electrical. Of course.

RAWAT
I'll need those registers for the inquiry. Evidence.

MAYA
(stepping in front of the trunk)
They're wet, Inspector. Let them dry. You can take them in the morning.

Rawat holds her gaze, then smiles.

RAWAT
In the morning, then.

He walks out. Maya turns to Nikhil.

MAYA
Sit on that trunk. Nobody touches it. Not even the firemen.

NIKHIL
Mom, I'm not a child.

MAYA
Then for once, act like the son of Vijay Sood.

Nikhil sits on the trunk. He doesn't move again.

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, BACK OFFICE - NIGHT

Three in the morning. Isha plugs the pen drive into the laptop. Alone. She clicks play.

ON SCREEN: CCTV, Corridor 2, 14 November, 01:58: A man in a police coat knocks on Room 214, carrying a steel thermos.

The man turns toward the camera. Inspector Rawat.

ON SCREEN: CCTV, 02:40: Rawat leaves Room 214, wiping the thermos with a handkerchief.

Isha covers her mouth.

A floorboard creaks behind her. A calm, deep voice.

RAWAT
You shouldn't have watched that, Isha.

EPISODE 10: Not Even K

INT. PINECREST HOTEL, BACK OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

Rawat stands in the doorway, his service pistol in his hand. Calm. Almost sad.

RAWAT
Close the laptop. Slowly.

Isha closes it. Her phone lies face down beside it.

ISHA
Why? He called you a friend.

RAWAT
He was a friend. Then he found a few old registers and became a saint.

ISHA
You poisoned him.

RAWAT
I made him tea. Ginger, the way he liked it. He drank it while telling me he was going to the press.

ISHA
And Kabir's locker?

RAWAT

A case needs someone to blame. Kabir was convenient. So was your stepmother's fear.

ISHA

And the fire?

RAWAT

Old wiring.

He steps closer.

RAWAT

Now give me the pen drive. Or this hotel has another heart attack.

Isha slides the pen drive across the desk.

ISHA

Take it. It's a copy.

Rawat's eyes flick to her phone. She turns it over. A live call to Zoya. Recording.

ZOYA

(from the phone) Every word, Inspector. And the SP heard all of it.

Rawat raises the gun. Kabir crashes through the side door and slams into him. The gun skids across the floor. Nikhil kicks it away.

Blue lights flood the windows. Maya walks in with the SP and four officers.

MAYA

Your file is closed, Inspector.

The officers cuff Rawat and lead him out into the snow.

EXT. PINECREST HOTEL, GARDEN - DAWN

The snow has stopped. Smoke still curls from the archive window. Isha stands with Kabir, Maya and Nikhil. Zoya walks up with a singed envelope.

ZOYA
This was inside the steel trunk. It's addressed to you.

Isha opens it. A second will, dated 13 November.

ON SCREEN: Will in Dad's handwriting: "Half of the Pinecrest goes to Isha. The other half goes to my daughter, Zoya."

Isha looks up slowly.

ISHA
Your daughter?

ZOYA
I came here to tell you, not to take anything. I just didn't know how.

ISHA
You're... my sister?

ZOYA
He found me six months ago. I'm not just his source, Isha. I'm his daughter.